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How AI Code Review Works

Understand the technologies behind automated code review and where they still need a human in the loop.

For developers and team leads who want to understand what AI code review tools actually check and where they fall short · 27 July 2026

Every section, key point, term and question from the full lesson is here. The extended explanations and the additional examples are not.

[Watch the source video](#)[Read the full lesson](#)[Read the highlights](#)

BEFORE YOU START

- Basic familiarity with git and the pull-request workflow
- General awareness of what a linter or static analyzer does

Overview

A pull request sits waiting for a human reviewer, the branch drifts, and by the time feedback arrives it takes almost as long to resolve the merge conflicts as it did to write the code. AI code review exists to close that gap: instead of relying only on people to read every diff, software analyzes the code itself, flags problems, and in many cases proposes a fix.

Under the hood, "AI code review" is not one technique. It is a stack of older, well-understood tools (static analysis, dynamic analysis, rule-based linting) combined with large language models that add contextual reasoning fixed rules cannot. Each layer catches a different class of problem, and none of them replaces judgment about whether a change is actually the right one to make.

This lesson works through what each layer checks, why teams adopt the combination, where it breaks (false positives, false negatives, over-reliance on the model), and how to roll it out without losing the human review step that catches what the tooling misses.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- ✓ AI code review layers several techniques: static analysis (before running code), dynamic analysis (while it runs), rule-based linting, and LLMs that add contextual understanding on top.
- ✓ Static analysis parses source text for syntax errors, style violations, and known-bad patterns without ever executing the code.
- ✓ Dynamic analysis, including DAST (Dynamic Application Security Testing), tests the running application by sending real inputs and observing behavior, catching runtime issues static analysis cannot see.
- ✓ Rule-based linters enforce fixed, deterministic style and safety rules; LLMs go further by recognizing patterns and intent that no fixed rule set was written to cover.
- ✓ Consistency is a structural benefit: an AI reviewer applies the same standard to every PR, where two human reviewers can reasonably disagree on what to prioritize.
- ✓ AI review is not free of error: it produces false positives (flagging non-issues) and false negatives (missing real vulnerabilities), so it augments human review rather than replacing it.
- ✓ Context engineering, structuring what information the model receives about your codebase and standards, directly determines how relevant its suggestions are.
- ✓ Successful adoption requires encoding team standards somewhere the AI can read them, integrating the tool into the existing PR workflow, and tracking whether it actually improves defect rates and review turnaround, not just adding noise.

01 The pull-request bottleneck AI code review is meant to fix

0:00

Slow, inconsistent human review creates a compounding cost: the longer a PR waits, the more it drifts from main, and the friction spreads across the whole pipeline from PR to production.

KEY POINTS

- Review latency and code drift compound each other: a slow review is more likely to also require conflict resolution.
- The friction shows up across the whole pipeline (PR -> CI -> deploy), not just in the review step itself.
- AI code review targets the mechanical parts of review (style, known bug patterns, security checks) so humans can focus on design and intent.
- The goal is a faster loop overall, not eliminating the human reviewer.

How a delay compounds into rework

A PR touching a shared utility function is opened on Monday. Review does not start until the following Monday. In that week, three other PRs modified the same file. The original author now has to resolve conflicts across all three changes, re-run tests, and in some cases redesign their approach because the utility function's signature changed underneath them, turning a same-day review into multiple days of rework.

02 What AI code review actually is

0:44

AI code review is software that uses machine learning and large language models to scan code changes, detect problems such as security flaws or style violations, and often propose a fix, working alongside (not instead of) human reviewers.

KEY POINTS

- AI code review = ML/LLM-based analysis of code changes to detect issues and recommend fixes.
- It goes beyond fixed rules by recognizing patterns in code the way it recognizes patterns in natural language.
- It typically produces both a flagged issue and an explanation, not just a pass/fail signal.
- It exists because manual review time scales worse than codebase size and PR volume.

A flagged SQL injection with a suggested fix

An AI reviewer scanning a diff sees a query built by string concatenation of a request parameter. It recognizes the pattern as a SQL injection risk (untrusted input reaching a query string unescaped) and proposes replacing the concatenation with a parameterized query.

```
# Flagged by AI review: untrusted input concatenated into SQL
def get_user(username):
    query = "SELECT * FROM users WHERE username = '" + username + "'"
    return db.execute(query)

# Suggested fix: parameterized query, input never touches the SQL string
def get_user(username):
    query = "SELECT * FROM users WHERE username = %s"
    return db.execute(query, (username,))
```

03 Why teams adopt it: consistency, learning, and less technical debt

2:13

Beyond speed, AI review applies the same standard on every PR, turns feedback into a learning moment for the author, and catches problems while they are still cheap to fix.

KEY POINTS

- Consistency: the same standard applies to every PR regardless of which human happens to review it.
- Learning: fast, explained feedback reaches the author while context is fresh, especially valuable for junior developers.
- Technical debt: issues caught earlier in the lifecycle are cheaper to fix than the same issues found in production.
- None of these benefits require removing the human reviewer, they change what the human spends their time on.

Same PR, two human reviewers, two different focuses

Reviewer A approves a PR after confirming it reads clearly and matches team naming conventions, but does not notice an N+1 query pattern. Reviewer B, reviewing a similar PR from the same author a week later, focuses heavily on performance and query counts but lets a naming inconsistency through. An AI reviewer configured with both concerns checks for both on every PR, independent of who is assigned.

04 Static code analysis: catching problems before code runs

3:40

Static analysis inspects source code without executing it, looking for syntax errors, security risks, and violations of coding standards before the code ever ships.

KEY POINTS

- Static analysis never executes the code, it only parses and inspects the source.
- It catches syntax errors, security risks, and coding-standard violations before deployment.
- It is cheap enough to run on every commit or PR, unlike full test suites.
- AI tools use static analysis output as one input among several when recommending fixes.

A static analyzer flagging a hardcoded secret

A static analysis tool (for example, a Python security linter such as bandit) scans a file and flags an API key committed directly in source, without ever running the program.

```
# Flagged: hardcoded secret detected by static analysis
API_KEY = "sk_live_51Hxyz..." # B105: hardcoded credential

# Fix: load from environment, never commit the value
import os
API_KEY = os.environ["STRIPE_API_KEY"]
```

05 Dynamic code analysis and DAST: testing the running app

4:29

Dynamic analysis tests software while it executes, uncovering runtime vulnerabilities and performance bottlenecks that static analysis cannot see because they only appear when the code actually runs.

KEY POINTS

- Dynamic analysis requires the application to actually be running, unlike static analysis.
- It catches runtime-only issues: race conditions, performance bottlenecks, behavior that depends on execution.
- DAST specifically simulates real-world attacks against a running application and logs unusual responses.
- Because it is slower and needs a live environment, it typically runs less often than static checks (e.g. nightly or per-deploy rather than per-commit).

A DAST-style probe against a login endpoint

A DAST tool sends a classic SQL injection payload as the username field on a live login endpoint. If the application returns a 200 with a valid session instead of rejecting the malformed input, that behavior gets logged as a finding, something a static read of the code might have missed if the vulnerable query was built dynamically.

```
curl -X POST https://staging.example.com/api/login \  
  -H "Content-Type: application/json" \  
  -d '{"username": "admin" OR '1'='1", "password": "anything"}'  
  
# Expected: 401 Unauthorized  
# Finding logged if the response is: 200 OK with a valid session token
```

06 Rule-based systems, linters, and where LLMs add reasoning

5:16

Linters and other rule-based systems enforce fixed coding guidelines deterministically; large language models go further because they are trained on enough code, documentation, and discussion to recognize context and meaning, not just pattern matches against a fixed rule list.

KEY POINTS

- Rule-based systems (including linters) enforce fixed, explicit rules deterministically.
- Their limitation: they only catch what a rule was explicitly written for, nothing outside that list.
- LLMs are trained on code, documentation, APIs, and discussion, so they recognize contextual and semantic patterns, not just syntactic ones.
- The two are complementary in practice: fixed rules for non-negotiable standards, LLMs for judgment calls.

A rule a linter can express vs. one it cannot

An ESLint rule can deterministically forbid the use of `==` in favor of `===`, because that is a fixed syntactic pattern. It cannot express "this retry loop has no backoff and will hammer the downstream service under failure," because recognizing that requires understanding what the code is trying to accomplish, which is the kind of judgment an LLM-based reviewer can approximate and a fixed rule cannot.

```
// .eslintrc rule: deterministic, syntactic
{
  "rules": {
    "eqeqeq": ["error", "always"]
  }
}

// Semantic issue no lint rule catches: missing backoff
function fetchWithRetry(url) {
  for (let i = 0; i < 5; i++) {
    try {
      return fetchSync(url);
    } catch (e) { /* retries immediately, no delay */ }
  }
}
```

07 Reaching beyond the codebase: tools, docs, and context engineering

6:44

Modern AI review systems connect to developer environments, testing frameworks, documentation, and even the live web, rather than relying only on what the model learned during training, making the analysis more current and more aware of a project's actual context.

KEY POINTS

- AI review tools increasingly connect to external systems (test frameworks, docs, live environments), not just the model's training data.
- Context engineering means deliberately structuring the information given to the model so its output is relevant and accurate.
- Output quality depends heavily on the context supplied, not on the model alone.
- Two teams with the same underlying model can get very different review quality based on integration depth.

Context changes the verdict on the same diff

A PR changes a function's return type from a list to a generator. Without context, an AI reviewer sees a plausible refactor and approves it. With the internal API documentation supplied as context, it sees that three downstream services call this function expecting a list they can index into, and flags the change as a breaking API contract violation instead.

08 Where AI code review breaks down

7:24

Three real limitations: developers can over-rely on automated feedback and stop thinking about architecture, the model may lack project-specific context, and it will produce both false positives and false negatives.

KEY POINTS

- Over-reliance: developers can stop exercising architectural judgment if they treat AI approval as sufficient.
- Missing context: without project-specific information, the model reasons from generic patterns that may not fit.
- False positives waste time and cause alert fatigue; false negatives create false confidence by missing real issues.
- These are structural limitations, not bugs to be fixed once, which is why human oversight remains necessary.

A false negative from missing context

An AI reviewer approves a change that adds a new admin-only endpoint, because the code itself, read in isolation, is syntactically correct and follows style conventions. It has no way to know the endpoint was never added to the authorization middleware's route list, so it misses a real access-control vulnerability that a human familiar with the auth system would have caught by checking the middleware config alongside the diff.

09 Adopting AI code review without losing human judgment

8:09

Rolling it out well means choosing a tool that fits your stack, encoding your standards somewhere the AI can read them, integrating into the existing PR workflow, tracking whether it actually improves quality signals, and keeping a human as the final reviewer

throughout.

KEY POINTS

- Choose a tool that fits your existing stack and workflow rather than forcing a workflow change to fit the tool.
- Encode team coding standards in a dedicated, evergreen instruction file both developers and AI tools reference.
- Integrate directly into the IDE or PR flow so feedback arrives where developers already work.
- Track quality signals (defect rate, review turnaround time, vulnerability detection) to confirm the tool is actually helping.
- Keep a human as the final reviewer; AI provides speed and pattern recognition, humans provide judgment and context.

A minimal team standards file an AI reviewer can reference

A short, version-controlled instructions file that encodes standards explicitly, so the AI reviewer's feedback matches how the team actually wants code written instead of generic defaults.

```
# review-standards.md

## Security
- Never build SQL with string concatenation; use parameterized queries.
- Secrets must come from environment variables, never hardcoded.

## Style
- Functions longer than 40 lines should be flagged for a split.
- Prefer explicit return types on public functions.

## Architecture
- New endpoints must be registered in auth/routes.yaml before merge.
- Flag any change to a function referenced in api-contracts.md as breaking.
```

Glossary

AI code review

The use of machine learning and large language models to automatically scan code changes, detect problems, and often suggest fixes, alongside human reviewers.

Static code analysis

Inspecting source code for syntax errors, security risks, and style violations without executing it.

Dynamic code analysis

Testing software while it is actually running, to uncover runtime issues like performance bottlenecks and race conditions that static analysis cannot see.

DAST (Dynamic Application Security Testing)

A form of dynamic analysis that simulates real-world attacks against a running application by sending crafted inputs and logging unusual or insecure responses.

Rule-based system

A tool, such as a linter, that enforces a fixed, explicit set of coding rules deterministically, catching only what a rule was written to detect.

Large language model (LLM)

A model trained on large amounts of text, including code, documentation, and discussion, that can recognize contextual and semantic patterns beyond fixed rules.

Context engineering

Deliberately structuring the information (standards, docs, related code) given to a model so its output is relevant and accurate to a specific project.

False positive

A case where a review tool flags code as a problem when it is not actually one, wasting reviewer time.

False negative

A case where a review tool fails to flag a real issue, creating false confidence that the code is safe.

Technical debt

The accumulated cost of shortcuts and unresolved issues in a codebase, which grows more expensive to fix the longer it goes unaddressed.

Check yourself

Answer first, then open each one.

Why does a slow PR review process create more work than just the delay itself?

Because the codebase keeps changing while the PR waits, so a long delay means the branch drifts further from main, producing merge conflicts and rework in addition to the lost time, not just a longer wait.

Why can't static analysis catch a race condition, and what technique can?

Static analysis only parses source text without executing it, so it cannot observe timing-dependent behavior between threads. Dynamic analysis, which runs the program and observes its actual behavior, can surface issues that only appear at runtime.

Why do large language models catch issues that rule-based linters miss?

Linters check code against a fixed, explicit list of rules and only catch what someone thought to write a rule for. LLMs are trained on enough code and discussion to recognize contextual and semantic patterns, so they can flag issues (like a poor architectural choice) that no one wrote an explicit rule for.

A team rolls out an AI reviewer without documenting their coding standards anywhere. What's the likely result, and why?

The reviewer's feedback will be generic rather than tailored to the team's actual conventions, because without an explicit reference (like an instruction file) the model has no project-specific context to reason from and falls back on general patterns from training.

Why can't a review system be tuned to eliminate both false positives and false negatives at once?

The two trade off against each other: making a detector stricter (to catch more real issues, reducing false negatives) also makes it more likely to flag non-issues (increasing false positives), and loosening it does the reverse. This trade-off is why human review remains necessary as a final check.

Why does the video argue that tracking metrics like defect rate and review turnaround time matters after adopting an AI review tool?

Because without measuring outcomes, a team can't tell whether the tool is actually improving the development process or just adding noise to review threads; the metrics are what distinguish genuine improvement from busywork.

Where to go next

- Run a static analyzer (e.g. bandit for Python, ESLint for JavaScript) against an existing project and compare its findings to what a human reviewer catches on the same diff.
- Try writing a short DAST-style test against a local app (a scripted request with a malformed or malicious payload) and see what the application actually does with it.
- Draft a one-page coding-standards instruction file for a real project and check whether it changes the feedback an AI review tool gives on the same PR before and after.
- Look into how your team currently measures review quality (turnaround time, escaped defects) and whether that data exists to evaluate an AI review tool honestly.

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Explanations are AI-generated. Check anything you intend to rely on.